

Christina Koch — Words to Build By

NASA astronaut. Record-holder for longest spaceflight by a woman (328 days). First woman to fly around the Moon (Artemis II). Electrical engineer, physicist, Antarctic researcher.

On Doing It for the Right Reasons

"Pursue what makes you happy and let that be the driving force to what gives your life meaning."

She deliberately chose **not** to follow a checklist to become an astronaut. She said she didn't want to live by a checklist just to get herself into space — she wanted the journey to be driven by genuine passion, not box-ticking.

Her path wasn't linear. She worked in Antarctica, Greenland, American Samoa — not because it was the "smart career move," but because she was drawn to extremes and vastness.

On Fear and Intimidation

"Using intimidation or feeling scared to actually fuel your success — turn it around and use that as motivation to achieve what you might not have thought was possible before."

She felt this first at science school, surrounded by brilliant peers. She didn't run from the discomfort. She learned to read fear as a signal that something *mattered*, not as a stop sign.

On Staying Curious

"I was inspired by everything I learned: Earth science, space science, astrophysics, geology — everything cool about the universe."

While working as an engineer, she reached *beyond* her assigned role — working on other missions, studying gamma rays, cosmic rays — not because she had to, but because she genuinely wanted to understand.

On Seeing Something Through

"It was great to see something to fruition."

She went back to engineering specifically to build something from inception to final design — and watched her instruments launch to Jupiter. She needed to *complete* something for herself before moving on.

On Representation and Inspiration

"We both drew a lot of inspiration from seeing people that were reflections of ourselves as we were growing up."

This is why she prioritised the first all-female spacewalk — because being *seen* matters. You seeing her matters. That's not weakness; that's how humans are wired to believe what's possible.

On Loving What Makes You Feel Small

She has always been drawn to the ocean, the night sky — "*anything that made me feel small.*"

There's something in this worth sitting with: the ego that drives burnout shrinks when you genuinely engage with something larger than yourself. Curiosity is the antidote to performance.

The Through-Line of Her Life

What she did	Why it matters to you
Didn't follow the checklist	Achievement driven by <i>external</i> approval burns out. She knew this.
Worked in extremes (Antarctica, space)	She put herself in hard conditions <i>by choice</i> , not by compulsion.
Rebuilt and redirected many times	Her path had detours. The astronaut career came after years of "other things."
Learned to use fear as fuel	Fear means it matters. Burnout means the fuel source was wrong.
Kept going back to what genuinely lit her up	Intrinsic motivation is the only sustainable kind.

A Note for You Specifically

You achieved hard things for a reason that wasn't yours. That's not failure — that's a misaligned fuel source. You now know the difference. That's actually further ahead than most people ever get.

Koch didn't become who she is by being a perfect student. She became who she is by keeping honest about *why* she was doing things — and only investing fully when the answer was real.

You're doing the same thing now. That's the work.